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WRITE/PRESENT/SIGN FOR A WIFE RANGE OF COMTEXTS

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Summative assessment

Task 1

Men are to be blamed for gender-based violence in South Africa

Gender-based violence, or GBV, is violence directed at a person because of their gender. In South Africa, it most often affects women, children, and members of the LGBTQ+ community. GBV includes physical assault, sexual violence, emotional abuse, economic abuse, and murder. South Africa has one of the highest rates of GBV in the world, and it has become a national crisis.

The statement "men are to be blamed for gender-based violence in South Africa" is both true and complicated. It is true that the majority of perpetrators of GBV are men. However, to say that "men" as a whole are to blame ignores the social, economic, and cultural factors that allow this violence to continue.

This essay will evaluate the statement by looking at evidence that supports it, other factors that contribute to GBV, and possible solutions. It will argue that while men are the main perpetrators, the blame must also be placed on the systems and attitudes that allow violence to thrive.

Evidence supporting the statement

The main reason people say "men are to be blamed" is because statistics show that men commit most acts of GBV. According to SAPS and NGO reports, over 80% of reported rape and domestic violence cases in South Africa have male perpetrators and female victims. Cases of intimate partner femicide — where a woman is killed by her male partner — are also extremely high.

One reason for this is patriarchy. South African society, like many others, has a history of male dominance. In many homes and communities, men are taught from a young age that they must be in control, that showing emotion is weak, and that using force is a way to solve problems. This idea of "toxic masculinity" teaches boys that power over others makes them a "real man." When this belief is combined with anger or stress, it can lead to violence against women and children.

Another factor is entitlement. Some men believe they have a right to control women's bodies, decisions,

and lives. This shows up in sexual violence, stalking, and domestic abuse. When a woman says “no” or tries to leave a relationship, some men respond with violence because they feel their authority is being challenged.Therefore, it is clear that men are directly responsible for the majority of GBV acts in South Africa.

Other contributing factors

However, blaming “all men” does not explain why GBV happens. There are other social and economic factors that create an environment where violence is more likely.

First, substance abuse plays a big role. Many GBV cases happen when the perpetrator is drunk or on drugs. Alcohol and drugs reduce a person’s ability to control anger and make impulsive decisions. This does not excuse the violence, but it explains why it increases on weekends and paydays.

Second, poverty and unemployment cause stress and frustration. When men feel they cannot provide for their families, some take out their anger on those closest to them. Financial dependence also makes it harder for women to leave abusive relationships.

Third, the cycle of violence is important. Many perpetrators grew up in homes where they saw violence or were abused themselves. They learn that violence is a normal way to deal with conflict. Without intervention, this pattern continues.

Finally, the justice system and community attitudes make the problem worse. Some cases are not reported because victims fear they won’t be believed. Others are dropped due to delays in court. In some communities, GBV is still seen as a “private family matter” instead of a crime. These attitudes allow perpetrators to continue without consequences.

Personal interest and the impact of GBV

GBV does not only hurt the direct victim. It affects families, schools, and entire communities. Children who grow up in violent homes often struggle in school and may repeat the same patterns as adults. Women who are abused may suffer from depression, anxiety, and physical injuries. This puts pressure on hospitals, police, and social services.

South Africa has tried to address GBV through campaigns like 16 Days of Activism, Thuthuzela Care Centres for rape victims, and laws like the Domestic Violence Act. NGOs also run programs to teach boys about respect and healthy relationships. But progress is slow because the root causes have not been fully addressed.

As a young person, I believe education is the key. Schools should teach about gender equality, consent, and conflict resolution from an early age. Men and boys must be part of the solution by speaking out against friends who make sexist jokes or use violence. Communities must stop protecting perpetrators and start supporting victims.

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In conclusion, men are responsible for the majority of gender-based violence in South Africa. The statistics prove this. However, to stop GBV we cannot just blame individuals. We must also address the patriarchy, poverty, substance abuse, and weak systems that allow violence to continue.

Blame alone will not solve the problem. What South Africa needs is action: better education, stronger law enforcement, economic opportunities, and a cultural shift where respect and equality are valued more than power and control.

If men, women, government, and communities work together, we can create a South Africa where everyone feels safe in their own home. GBV is not just a “women’s issue” or a “men’s issue.” It is a human issue, and it is everyone’s responsibility to end it.